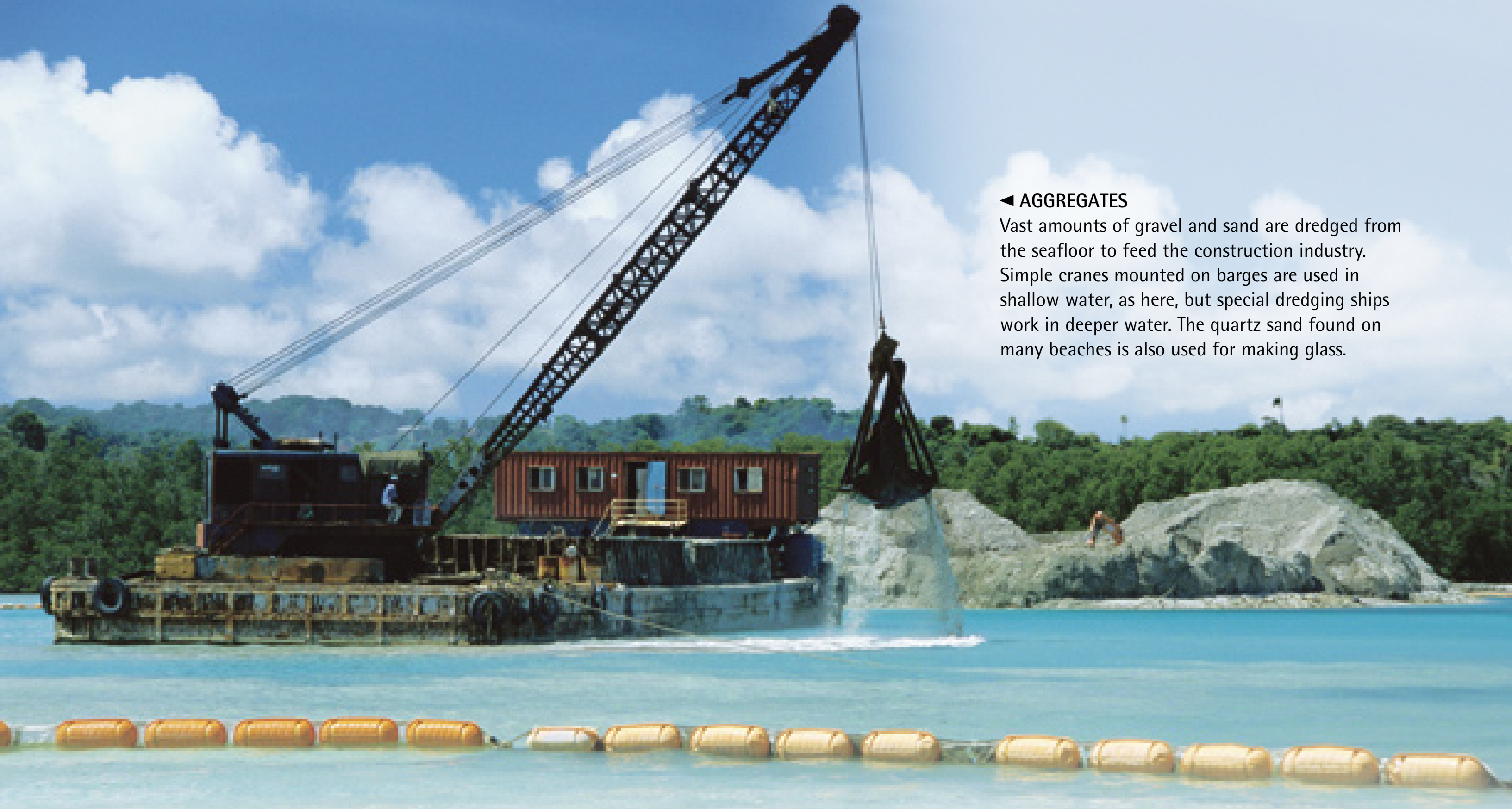
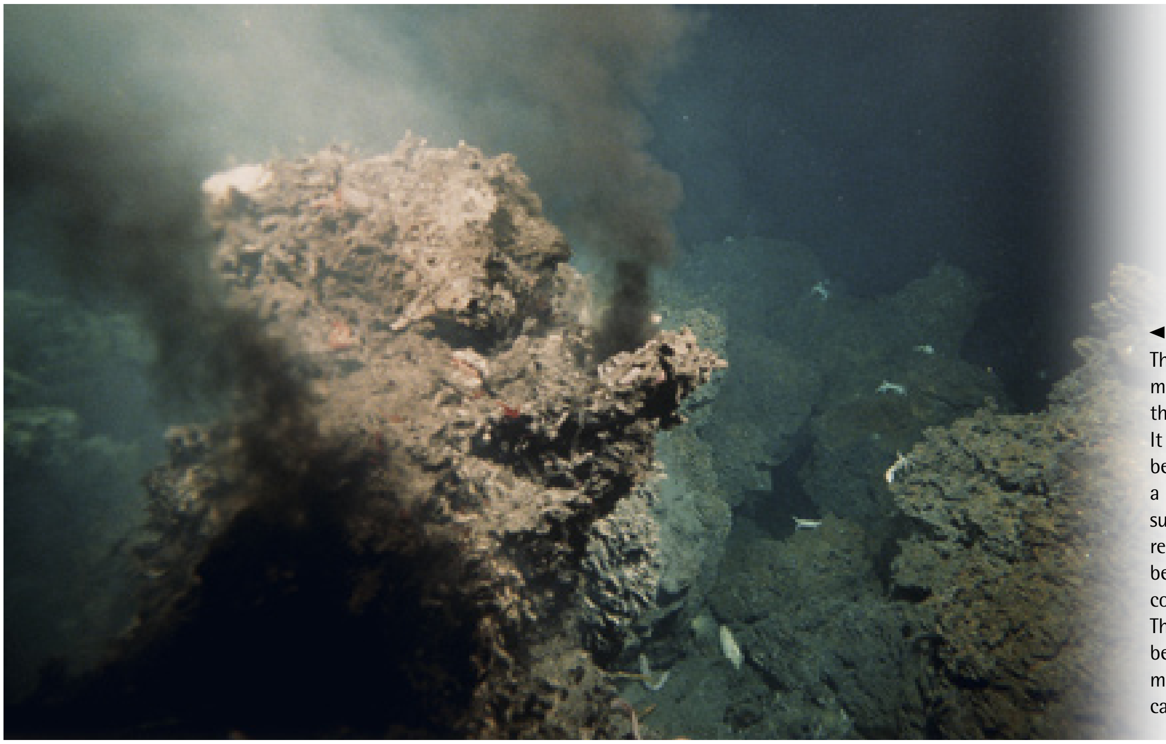


◄ AGGREGATES
Vast amounts of gravel and sand are dredged from the seafloor to feed the construction industry. Simple cranes mounted on barges are used in shallow water, as here, but special dredging ships work in deeper water. The quartz sand found on many beaches is also used for making glass.

◄ MANGANESE NODULES
Several parts of the deep ocean floor are covered with potato-sized nodules containing valuable elements such as manganese, cobalt, and titanium. But since they lie more than 13,000 ft (4,000 m) below the surface, harvesting them would cost more than they are worth.

◄ PEARLS AND DIAMONDS
The natural pearls formed within oyster shells have been gathered by pearl divers for centuries. Even more valuable, however, are the gemstones found on the barren Atlantic shores of southwest Africa, where the coastal sands contain diamonds carried off the continent by ancient rivers.



minerals

◄ METALS AND METHANE
The hydrothermal vents on mid-ocean ridges erupt hot water that is rich in dissolved metals. It is possible that these could be harvested, although they lie a long way beneath the ocean surface. There are also extensive reserves of frozen methane beneath the ocean floors, which could be tapped for natural gas. This might be hazardous, however, because the accidental release of methane on a large scale could cause catastrophic climate change.